More satisfying even than the landscape, or the prospects of a week's rest in the Mughal Emperor Babur's favourite pleasure resort at Istalif, was Burnes's firm conviction that an anti-Russian alliance was all but in the bag. 'Dost Mohammad Khan has fallen into all our views,' he wrote to his brother-in-law from Istalif the following day.

> Things now stand so that I think we are at the threshold of negotiations with King Ranjit, the basis of which will be his withdrawal from Peshawar and a Barakzai receiving it as a tributary of Lahore, the Chief of Kabul sending his son to ask pardon. Oh! What say you to this after all that has been urged [by Wade and Macnaghten] of Dost Mohammad Khan putting forth extravagant pretensions! Ranjit will accede to the plan, I am certain. I have, on behalf of the Government, agreed to stand as mediator between the parties, and Dost Mohammad has cut asunder all his connections with Persia and Russia and refused to receive the ambassadors from the Shah now at Kandahar.[60]

Burnes was not to know that, even as he wrote, several hundred miles to the south his mission was being sabotaged so as to make it almost impossible for him to reconcile the two warring partners. Still less was he to suspect as yet that the man who would effectively kill off his Embassy was the very same man who had despatched it, the new Governor General, Lord Auckland.

Around the same time as Burnes was writing in triumph from Istalif, and Vitkevitch and his Cossacks were cantering across the Afghan frontier south of Herat, a red cordon of ceremonial cavalry was lining up between the gates of Government House in Calcutta and the lapping waters of the riverfront ghats on the Hoogly.

Lord Auckland was about to leave Calcutta for his first trip outside Bengal. His imperial progress was planned to allow him to inspect the famine-struck plains of Hindustan, from the Kingdom of Avadh to the British-controlled North West Provinces. He was to travel first by a 'flat', a special viceregal barge pulled by a steamer, then at Benares to continue by road, in carriage and palanquin, and on elephant-back, up through the Punjab to the newly established hill station of Simla.

George Eden, Lord Auckland, was a clever and capable but somewhat complacent and detached Whig nobleman. He was of a delicate build, with a thin, boyish face, narrow lips and long, elegant fingers. A confirmed bachelor of fifty-one, but looking a decade younger, he made little secret of